advisers and lacked support of his own party (and the wider Hindu nationalist movement) on key policies. Former officials who worked with Vajpayee, including some of his confidants, say that his principal secretary and national security adviser, Brajesh Mishra, was virtually his main adviser and executor of foreign policy.

The task of articulating the BJP's foreign policy views to the world fell to Jaswant Singh, who served as Vajpayee's external affairs minister. In his book *Defending India* (1999), Singh outlined the core elements of this world view. To Vajpayee and Singh, the US was a friend rather than a threat, China was not a natural ally of India (unlike what Nehru believed till 1962) and India needed to build its economic and military power because that is what would make India acceptable by the world as a major power.[133] It was not surprising, therefore, that tests declaring India as a nuclear weapons power took place under a BJP government in 1998. An assertive India was able to improve relations with Pakistan, China and the United States even though India and Pakistan fought their fourth war, the Kargil conflict, in 1999.

After five years in office, Vajpayee and the BJP lost the 2004 parliamentary elections, paving the way for the return to office of the Congress party, this time at the head of a coalition government, the United Progressive Alliance (UPA). Manmohan Singh, the technocrat and reformist finance minister in the last Congress government, was chosen as prime minister and he remained in office for two successive terms, spanning the decade from 2004 to 2014. Singh was known as the architect of India's economic liberalization, leading to a lot of expectations, especially in further opening up of India's economy. He was hemmed in by the fact that the Congress party chief, Sonia Gandhi, and not the prime minister wielded real power. Sonia controlled the Congress party machine and Manmohan Singh had no popular political base. In the end, Sonia's views on the economy and on India's role in the world prevailed. These were reminiscent